A corpus-based investigation
of the unification of word-formation schemas in Hungarian

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Introduction

Morphological segmentation typically works well in Hungarian for inflected words, but for word formation it is often difficult to decide whether a word involves an affix complex or a series of consecutive derivational affixes (Keszler 2017). There are also typical patterns of sequences of derivational affixes in Hungarian (Palágyi–Tóth-Czifra–Benczes 2020), which can be described as multiple source-oriented generalizations in a usage-based framework (see Bybee 2001). The background to multiple source-oriented generalizations is that derivational constructions (see Booij 2010) are networking, so that the derivational operation always goes beyond the relation between a base and a derivative (see Nathout–Namer 2019). Accordingly, for example, the derivative *erő-s-ít* strenght-ADJZ-VZ ‘make sg/sy stronger’ can be described as a result of multiple source-oriented generalization of [[[N]-(V)*s*]$_{\text{ADJ}}$-*ít*]$_{\text{V}}$ (see *erő* ‘strenght’ : *erő-s* ‘strong’ : *erő-s-ít* ‘make sg/sy stronger’ ~ *ideg* ‘nerve’ : *ideg-es* ‘nervous’ : *ideg-es-ít* ‘make sy nervous’), or as the result of [[ADJ]-*ít*]$_{\text{V}}$ source-oriented generalization (see *erős* ‘strong’ : *erős-ít* ‘make sg/sy stronger’ ~ *meleg* ‘warm’ : *meleg-ít* ‘make sg/sy warmer’) depending on the part of the derivation network on which the derivative is mapped. Multiple source-oriented generalizations explain how a derivational operation can apply to non-existent (or potential) words (see *tanú* ‘witness’ → **tanú-s* → *tanú-s-ít* ‘certify’). The latter phenomenon is also an indicator that two (or more) word-formation schemas are evolving towards unification (Booij 2010: 41–50; 2015). This process of language change involving word-formation schemas can be investigated in corpora.

Materials and methods

The present corpus-based research investigates the unification of the adjectivizer -(V)*s*, verbalizers expressing change of state, and preverb-verb constructions. During data collection, we extract all relevant derivatives from the HGC-UD (Kalivoda et al. 2023). Each item in the resulting list is compared with the frequency with which the adjective lemma occurs without a verbalizer and the frequency with which the verb lemma occurs without a preverb. We compare the frequency of each adjective lemma ending in *s* with and without any verbalizer suffix, and of each verb lemma with and without any preverb. As detailed above, we assume that unification has occurred when the verb expressing a change of state is much more frequent than the adjectival base with *s* adjectivizer ending, and when the verb with a preverb is much more frequent than the verb without it. An important methodological issue in our research is what exactly we mean by "much more frequent". To answer this question, we develop our own metrics based on the corpus data. The derivatives, which can be considered as typical realizations of the combined constructions, are also compared to data from the Hungarian Historical Corpus (Csengery 2006).

Results

The comparison of 19th century, 20th century and present-day data shows that the unification of word-formation constructions is evident at the level of instances and schemas alike. Some of the derivates that can be considered typical representatives on the basis of present-day data have been continuously chunked from the 19th century onwards, while others can only be registered in a chunked form from the second half of the 20th century. The usage-based explanation is that, in addition to the network organization of schemas, the chunking of instances is also responsible for schema unification, since the schemas are elaborated analogously to the existing instances.

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